# AI SEARCH TRENDS 2026

*The numbers and rule changes that matter, dated and sourced.*

Who is asking AI, what a visit from it is worth, how fast the answers change, and every rule change of 2026 in one table.

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**Who it is for.** Anyone deciding how much attention AI search deserves this year.

Every number names its source; the full list is on the last page. Updated 7 October 2026.

01

# WHO IS ASKING

**900M**

people use ChatGPT every week.

Source: TechCrunch

**1B+**

use Google's AI Mode every month.

Source: Google

**47%**

of US patients have used AI to research a provider.

Source: rater8

**45%**

of US consumers use AI tools for local business recommendations, up from 6% in a year.

Source: BrightLocal

**51%**

of B2B software buyers start research in an AI chatbot more often than Google.

Source: G2

**54%**

of UK adults use AI tools such as ChatGPT, up from 31% a year earlier.

Source: Ofcom

02

# WHAT A VISIT IS WORTH

**1.66%**

sign-up rate from AI referrals, against 0.15% from search, across 1,277 sites.

Source: Microsoft Clarity

**4.4×**

the value of an AI search visitor against an organic search visitor.

Source: MarTech

**12.1%**

of Ahrefs' sign-ups came from the 0.5% of visitors sent by AI search.

Source: Ahrefs

03

# HOW FAST THE ANSWERS CHANGE

## <1%

chance the same question returns the same list of brands twice.

Source: Search Engine Journal

## 74%

of the domains ChatGPT cites change from one week to the next. For Google AI Mode it is 56%.

Source: SISTRIX

## 60% → 10%

Reddit's share of ChatGPT responses, before and after mid-September 2025.

Source: Semrush

> *One screenshot is not a measurement. Ask the question many times and count.*

04

# WHAT GETS CITED

## 43.8%

of the pages ChatGPT cites are "best of" lists.

Source: Ahrefs

## 0.664

correlation between mentions on other sites and ChatGPT visibility. Pages on your own site: 0.194.

Source: Ahrefs

## 25.7%

fresher: pages AI assistants cite, against pages in classic results.

Source: Ahrefs

05

# EVERY RULE CHANGE OF 2026

| DATE | WHO | WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|
| **15 September 2026** | Cloudflare | New domains block AI bots classified as Training or Agent on pages that show ads, by default. Search crawlers stay allowed. |
| **31 August 2026** | Google | Search generative AI control rolled out to every Search Console property: include or exclude a site from AI Overviews, AI Mode and generative Discover. |
| **26 August 2026** | Chrome | Guidance published on building WebMCP tools; the API is in origin trial from Chrome 149. |
| **22 July 2026** | Google | AI Mode passes 1 billion monthly users; AI Overviews and AI Mode merged into one Search experience; Google says AI features send billions of clicks a week. |
| **10 July 2026** | Google | Guide to optimising for generative AI features updated: non-commodity content matters most; llms.txt, chunking and special schema are not needed; fan-out pages count as scaled content abuse. |
| **1 July 2026** | Cloudflare | All plans can manage AI traffic by behaviour: Search, Agent and Training, each allowed or blocked separately. |
| **18 May 2026** | Chrome | WebMCP announced: a proposed standard for websites to expose tools to AI agents. |
| **24 March 2026** | OpenAI | Richer product discovery and shopping in ChatGPT, powered by the Agentic Commerce Protocol. |
| **27 February 2026** | OpenAI | ChatGPT reaches 900 million weekly active users. |
| **10 February 2026** | Microsoft | AI Performance report in Bing Webmaster Tools: citations in Copilot and Bing AI answers, cited pages and grounding queries. |
| **30 January 2026** | SparkToro | Research: AI tools return the same brand list less than 1% of the time for the same prompt. |
| **11 January 2026** | Google | Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP) detailed: an open standard for agentic buying in AI Mode and Gemini. |

06

# WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- Measure your odds of being named, every month, across more than one engine.
- Put as much work into the lists, directories and reviews as into your own pages.
- Keep pages dated and current. Engines favour what was updated recently.

NEXT STEP

# FIFTEEN MINUTES. NO PITCH DECK.

Tell us the questions your patients or buyers ask. We will show you who the AI names for them.

BOOK A CALL

CAL.COM/SOLVX-AI/15MIN

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